“Only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible.”

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Where it often comes from

Feeling intimidated by the Bible’s size, history, or language. Church settings where only leaders explained Scripture. Past attempts to read that ended in confusion. Limited schooling or reading difficulties. Being told not to interpret the Bible for yourself.

What Scripture teaches

Pastors and scholars are gifts to the church, and their help is valuable. But God gave His Word to all His people. The law of the LORD makes wise the simple, and the unfolding of His words gives light to the simple. Peter and John were unschooled, ordinary men, yet people saw that they had been with Jesus. The Holy Spirit teaches believers. Timothy learned the Scriptures as a child. You can read and understand God’s Word, and grow in it.

> *“The unfolding of Your words gives light; it informs the simple”* **(Psalm 119:130)**.

Also see

> “The Law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is trustworthy, making wise the simple” **(Psalm 19:7)**.

> “But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have told you” **(John 14:26)**.

> “When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus” **(Acts 4:13)**.

> “From infancy you have known the Holy Scriptures, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus” **(2 Timothy 3:15)**.

Common self-statements

- I’m not smart enough to understand the Bible.
- I need a pastor to tell me what it means.
- The Bible is too hard for ordinary people.
- I’ll just get it wrong.
- Only experts should read it seriously.
- I don’t have enough education.

Common logical errors

- **Discounting yourself:** Believing you cannot understand what God gave to all His people.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must understand everything or nothing.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Avoiding Scripture for fear of misunderstanding.
- **Overreliance on others:** Letting others do all your Bible reading for you.

Challenging questions

- Who does Psalm 19:7 say God's Word makes wise?
- What did people notice about Peter and John, who were unschooled?
- What does the Holy Spirit do, according to John 14:26?
- Did Timothy learn the Scriptures as a child?
- Can I understand some of the Bible now and grow over time?
- Who could help me start?
- What part of the Bible could I begin with?

Truth summary

> I can understand the Bible. God gave His Word to all His people, and it makes wise the simple. The Holy Spirit teaches me. Pastors and scholars can help, but I do not have to depend on them for everything. I can read, grow, and understand more over time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Scripture/Word
- Holy Spirit
- Wisdom
- Intelligence
- Truth

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who does God's Word make wise?
- ☐ What did people notice about Peter and John?
- ☐ What does the Holy Spirit do?
- ☐ Did Timothy learn Scripture as a child?
- ☐ Can I understand some now and grow?
- ☐ Where could I begin?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's Word makes wise the simple.
- ☐ The Holy Spirit teaches me.
- ☐ God gave His Word to all His people.
- ☐ I can understand the Bible and grow over time.
- ☐ Ordinary people can know God through His Word.
- ☐ The unfolding of His words gives light.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 119:130**
  "The unfolding of Your words gives light; it informs the simple."
- [ ] **Psalm 19:7**
  "The Law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is trustworthy, making wise the simple."
- [ ] **John 14:26**
  "But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have told you."
- [ ] **Acts 4:13**
  "When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus."
- [ ] **2 Timothy 3:15**
  "From infancy you have known the Holy Scriptures, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Understanding log:** Each day, write one thing I understood from what I read.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 119:130 becomes: "The unfolding of Your words gives light to **Sarah**; it informs **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Scripture/Word" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Start with the Gospel of Mark,** reading one short section each day.
- ☐ **Use a readable translation** or listen to an audio Bible.
- ☐ **Before reading, pray:** "Open my eyes, Holy Spirit," and write one thing you notice.
- ☐ **Join a small group Bible study** where people of all backgrounds learn together.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I understood
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for giving Your Word to all Your people. Help me reject the lie that only pastors or scholars can understand the Bible. Holy Spirit, teach me as I read, and give me confidence and joy in Your Word. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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